



In with the robot, out with the job?

American economists, Jeffrey Sachs and Laurence Kotlikoff are two experts who feel that such concerns are not without relevance in the present day. They ask a significant question: What if machines are getting so smart that they no longer need unskilled labour to operate?

They point out how smart machines are already doing jobs which have been entirely human domains until recently – like collecting highway tolls, checking customers out at stores, taking blood pressure, giving directions, answering phones, printing documents, flying planes, and teaching kids among other things. They also point out how this list is not at all exhaustive.

Looking at the economic metrics in America, some people – like Eric Brynjolfsson and Andrew McAfee of the Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) think that the concern could be justified.

They point out how the economic statistics that people care about the most rose together in America for decades after the second World War. The Gross Domestic Product (GDP) grew alongside productivity. Literally millions of jobs were created – many of these jobs were suited for those without a degree even. But then, the productivity growth and employment growth began to decouple from each other.

The decoupling data reveals that the US economy has been doing rather poorly for the bottom 90 percent of Americans for the last 4 decades. Technology has been improving productivity greatly during these decades which in turn resulted in a growing economy. However, most people don't get to benefit from the growth. Though the American economy still creates